

UNIT V



When the Bottom Fell Out

The Great Depression & the New Deal · 1929–1941

US.39

US.40

US.41

US.42

US.43

US.44

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

In 1929 the richest country on earth fell into its worst economic disaster, and one in four workers lost their jobs through no fault of their own. When the bottom falls out for millions of people, whose job is it to catch them — themselves, their neighbors, or their government? The answer America argued out in the 1930s still shapes your life today.

Everything you just saw glitter in the 1920s — the easy credit, the soaring stocks, the sense that the party would never stop — comes crashing down in this unit. In October 1929 the stock market collapsed, and it took the banks, the factories, the farms, and one in four people's jobs down with it. This is the Great Depression, the worst economic disaster in American history, and it forced the country to answer a question it had mostly dodged: when disaster strikes millions of people who did nothing wrong, whose job is it to help? You'll live it through five people. Dot, from the last unit, rode the boom on borrowed money and now loses everything. Opal watches her Oklahoma farm turn to dust and takes the long road west. Ruth sees the Depression hit Black Americans first and hardest in Harlem. Vernon, back in East Tennessee, witnesses the single most dramatic New Deal miracle in the country — the day the lights came on. And Frankie reports the whole fight over what a government is for. That fight gave us Social Security, the minimum wage, bank-deposit insurance, and the TVA — and an argument about government that America is still having today.

How this unit works

- Taught through story — you feel the crash, the dust, the breadline, and the lights coming on through people, not statistics.
- Multiple perspectives — Hoover's philosophy and FDR's, the New Deal's champions and its critics, each argued fairly.
- Primary sources — FDR's own inaugural and 'economic royalists' speech, Hoover's 'rugged individualism,' Steinbeck, and the era's unforgettable photographs.
- UDL — a present-day hook, plain-language summaries, cited images, and a choice of ways to respond on every spread.
- The civic cycle in full force — a disaster, a public demand, and the biggest government response in American history.
- The Arc of the Union — plot the collapse and the New Deal's climbs and controversies on the trajectory you're building all year.

Flight crew this unit:

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

Who you'll travel with in this unit



Dot, 27

A Northern industrial
city



Opal, 15

Cimarron County,
Oklahoma → Route 66
to California



Ruth, 32

Harlem, New York City



Vernon, 24

The Tennessee Valley,
East Tennessee



Frankie, 33

Washington, D.C. and
on assignment

Spread 1 • US.39

Analyze the interlocking causes of the Great Depression — margin buying, bank failures, overproduction, and the Smoot-Hawley Tariff.

🔔 You buy something with money you don't have, betting you'll pay it back when your investment goes up. Everybody's doing it, so it feels safe. Then, one day, the value drops — and suddenly everybody owes money they can't pay, all at once. That's not just a bad afternoon. In 1929 it was the start of the worst economic collapse in American history, and it began with a single word you already learned last unit: margin.

Archive holds the C-130 over Wall Street on October 29, 1929, as a huge crowd churns in the street below. 'Last unit you watched them build this boom on borrowed money,' she says. 'Today you watch the bill come due — and you watch it take down a whole country, one falling domino at a time.'



ERA-FRIEND

Dot • the bill comes due

You met Dot in the Twenties, buying the car and the radio on installment credit and letting friends talk her into 'playing the market' with borrowed money. Now it's October 1929, and the market crashes. The stocks people bought on margin — putting down a little and borrowing the rest — collapse, and the loans are still owed. Dot's small savings vanish when her bank, like more than nine thousand others between 1930 and 1933, simply fails; there's no deposit insurance, so the money is just gone. Dot did what everyone told her the modern world rewarded. She is about to spend a decade learning that the boom was built on a lie.

INSTITUTION

The dominoes • how a crash became a Depression

A stock crash alone doesn't have to become a decade-long Depression. This one did because the whole system was rigged to fall together. Factories had been making more goods than people could afford to buy — overproduction — so when spending slowed, they laid off workers, who then spent even less. Farmers had been in trouble since the war ended. In 1930 Congress passed the Smoot-Hawley Tariff to 'protect' American business, other nations retaliated, and world trade collapsed by roughly two-thirds. Each failure triggered the next: crash, bank failures, closings, layoffs, less spending, more failures — a vicious cycle with no bottom, until unemployment hit 25 percent.

 **Primary source:** “The fundamental business of the country, that is, the production and distribution of commodities, is on a sound and prosperous basis.” — President Herbert Hoover, public statement, October 25, 1929.

 Four days later the market suffered the worst crash in its history, and within four years more than 9,000 banks had failed. Ask: why would the president reassure the public like this — and how should you weigh official confidence against what was actually happening? A crowd photo can show panic, but the millions who would lose jobs and homes were mostly invisible. How do you ‘see’ a disaster this big?

In plain words: In October 1929 the stock market crashed. It became the Great Depression because many problems hit at once: people had bought stocks with borrowed money ('on margin'); over 9,000 banks failed and wiped out savings (no deposit insurance existed yet); factories had made more than people could buy (overproduction); farmers were already struggling; and the 1930 Smoot-Hawley Tariff collapsed world trade. Each failure caused the next, in a downward spiral, until one in four workers had no job by 1933.

 **Tennessee:** Tennessee had its own spectacular crash. In November 1930, Nashville's Caldwell and Company — once the largest financial firm in the entire South, run by Rogers Caldwell, 'the Morgan of the South' — collapsed. It took down banks and public funds across Tennessee and the region, showing that the Depression wasn't just a Wall Street story. It reached straight into the banks and pockets of Tennesseans.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** An unregulated, over-leveraged economy crashed and dragged the banking system and millions of jobs down with it.
- **Head out of the sand:** Economists, workers, and eventually voters who saw the market would not simply fix itself.
- **Voice raised:** Public demand for action grew as the crisis deepened, culminating in the 1932 election.
- **Government response:** Early federal responses were limited; sweeping reform (FDIC, SEC) came only with the New Deal.
- **Still unfinished:** How much to regulate finance to prevent the next crash is argued after every boom and bust since.

✓ **Check:** Explain how a stock market crash turned into a decade-long Depression. Identify at least three causes and show how one caused or worsened another.

Show what you know:

- Draw the 'domino chain' from the 1929 crash to 25% unemployment, labeling each cause.
- Write Dot's letter to her Unit 4 self, warning her about buying on margin.

- Debate: was the Depression caused more by individual choices or by systemic flaws? Use evidence.
-

Analyze the human-caused ecological disaster of the Dust Bowl and the forced migration and discrimination it produced.

🔊 Imagine the sky itself turning against you. A wall of black dust two thousand feet high, rolling across the horizon at sixty miles an hour, turning noon into midnight and burying your house, your car, your fields. It sounds like a disaster movie. It was real, it lasted years, and — here's the hard part — people helped cause it. The Dust Bowl is the decade's brutal lesson in what happens when we break the land that feeds us.

Archive drops the crew onto a cracked Oklahoma field as a dark smudge builds on the horizon. 'This one isn't only bad luck,' she says quietly. 'Watch how a drought and a way of farming collide — and watch what it does to a family that has nowhere left to plant.'



ERA-FRIEND

Opal • when the land dies

Opal is fifteen, and her family farms in Cimarron County, Oklahoma — the heart of what people will call the Dust Bowl. For years, farmers here (Opal's family included) plowed up the tough native prairie grass, the grass whose deep roots had always held the soil, to plant wheat. Then the rain stopped. Without the grass, the topsoil dried to powder and the wind simply carried it away in monstrous 'black blizzards.' Opal learns to stuff wet rags in the window cracks and still tastes grit in her food; the fine dust gets in people's lungs and kills them. When the family's land finally blows away, there is nothing to do but pack the car and drive.

PRIMARY VOICE

John Steinbeck • making America see

Opal's family becomes part of a huge migration: more than 400,000 people abandoned their Plains farms and drove west, mostly to California, along Route 66. They were called 'Okies' — and it was a slur. California didn't welcome them; it treated them as dirty, lazy, and inferior, and with so many desperate people competing for farm work, wages crashed and families lived in tent camps. In 1939 the writer John Steinbeck published *The Grapes of Wrath*, a novel about the fictional Joad family driven off the land, and it forced the country to see the 'Okies' as real human beings with dignity. A story did what statistics couldn't.



📷 Arthur Rothstein, Dust Bowl farmer raising fence, Cimarron County, Oklahoma, 1936.

Rothstein, Arthur. 'Farmer raising fence to keep it from being buried under drifting sand, Cimarron County, Oklahoma.' Photograph, 1936. Farm Security Administration, U.S. government (public domain).

💡 This is Arthur Rothstein's 1936 photograph of a farmer lifting a fence before the drifting sand buries it, in Opal's own Cimarron County. Ask: the government hired photographers to document the Dust Bowl. Why would a government want the country to see images like this — and how might that shape what got photographed?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



Dust Bowl buried farm machinery, Dallas, South Dakota, 1936.

In plain words: The Dust Bowl was a 1930s disaster on the southern Plains (Oklahoma, Texas, Kansas, and nearby). Farmers had plowed up the native prairie grass whose deep roots held the soil, to plant wheat. When a severe drought hit, the bare topsoil dried out and blew away in giant dust storms ('black blizzards') that buried farms and caused deadly 'dust pneumonia.' Over 400,000 people ('Okies') fled west to California, where they faced discrimination. John Steinbeck's novel *The Grapes of Wrath* (1939) helped the country see them as real people.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee wasn't in the Dust Bowl, but it knew the same enemy: exhausted, eroding land. Generations of row-crop farming had stripped and gullied Tennessee's hills, and the Depression pushed the state's already-poor farmers to the edge. The lesson of the Dust Bowl — that you cannot abuse the soil forever — is exactly what the New Deal's conservation programs and the TVA would soon set out to fix in Tennessee.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Unsustainable farming plus drought destroyed the land and displaced hundreds of thousands of people.
- **Head out of the sand:** Migrant families, documentary photographers and writers (Steinbeck), and government scientists.
- **Voice raised:** Migration, art and journalism, and calls for conservation and relief.
- **Government response:** The Soil Conservation Service (1935) taught sustainable farming, and New Deal programs aided migrants and the land.
- **Still unfinished:** Balancing food production against protecting soil, water, and climate is an ongoing challenge.

✓ **Check:** Explain why the Dust Bowl is called a 'human-caused' disaster, not just a natural one. Then describe what happened to families like Opal's, and how *The Grapes of Wrath* changed public understanding.

Show what you know:

- Write Opal's diary entry the day the family decides to leave Oklahoma.
 - Design a Soil Conservation Service poster teaching farmers how to keep soil from blowing away.
 - Debate: who was most responsible for the Dust Bowl — farmers, the government, or nature? Use evidence.
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Spread 3 • US.41

Analyze the human toll of the Great Depression — mass unemployment, Hoovervilles, hunger, and the unequal way it fell.

🔊 One in four. Picture your class, and cross out every fourth person's job — gone. Now imagine there's no unemployment check, no food stamps, no safety net of any kind, because none of that exists yet. That was 1933. The Great Depression wasn't a number on a chart; it was breadlines that stretched for blocks, families living in cardboard shacks, and kids your age riding freight trains alone, looking for work that wasn't there.

Archive walks the crew past a breadline snaking around a city block, then to a shantytown of scrap-wood shacks. 'No cameras pointed at the worst of it,' she says. 'But one photographer made a single image that finally made comfortable people feel it. Watch what a face can do.'



ERA-FRIEND

Dot • the shantytown

Dot has hit the bottom. Her job is gone, her savings vanished with the bank, and after the landlord's notice she ends up in a 'Hooverville' — a shantytown of homeless families built from cardboard and scrap, named in bitter mockery of the president. She learns the grim vocabulary of the poor: 'Hoover blankets' are newspapers you sleep under, a 'Hoover flag' is an empty pocket turned inside out. She stands in breadlines for a bowl of soup. The proud modern girl of the Twenties is discovering that in this disaster, hard work and good intentions guarantee you nothing at all.



ERA-FRIEND

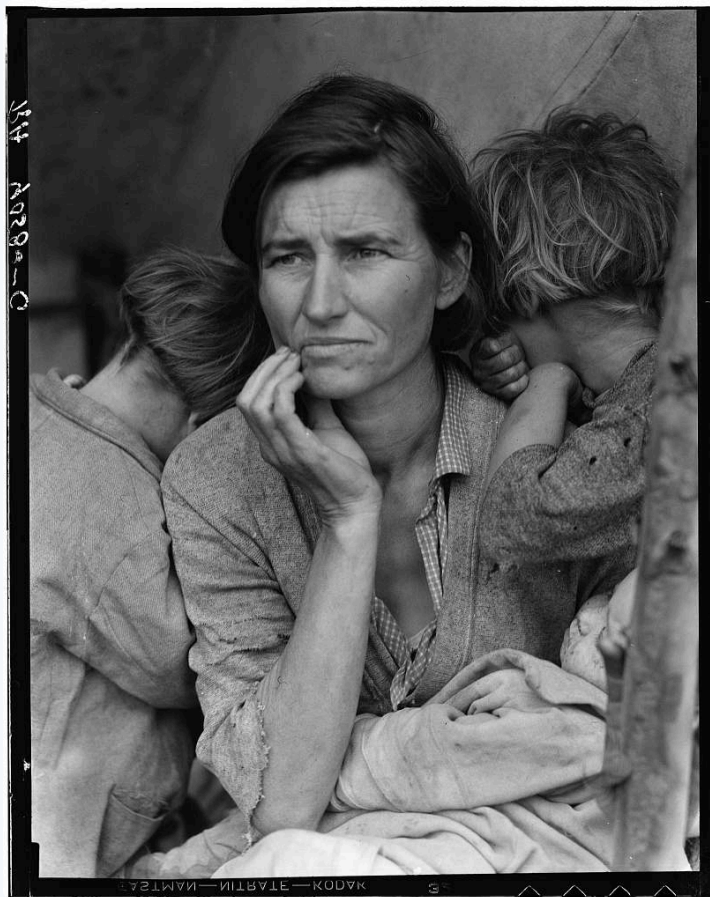
Ruth • first hired last, fired first

Ruth, who you met building a life in Harlem, sees a truth the general story often skips: the Depression did not fall evenly. Black Americans, already pushed to the bottom of the job ladder, were often the 'last hired and first fired,' and Black unemployment ran far higher than white. Communities that had climbed so hard in the Great Migration and the Harlem Renaissance were knocked back down. Ruth's perspective is essential to an honest account: when a country falls, the people who were already lowest have the farthest, and the hardest, distance to drop.

GROUP

The wandering country · riding the rails

The suffering was so widespread it set the whole country in motion. More than 250,000 teenagers — kids the age of a high-school junior — became hoboes, hopping freight trains to look for work, facing injury, arrest, and death on the rails; many families were separated and never reunited. Beneath the statistics was a quieter wound: the 'self-made man' ideal collapsed, and millions of people who had believed hard work guaranteed security felt shame, humiliation, and despair. It was a psychological scar a whole generation carried for the rest of their lives.



 Dorothea Lange, "Migrant Mother" (1936).

Lange, Dorothea. 'Destitute pea pickers in California. Mother of seven children. Age thirty-two. Nipomo, California' ("Migrant Mother"). Photograph, February 1936. Farm Security Administration, U.S. government (public domain).

 This is Dorothea Lange's 'Migrant Mother' (1936) — maybe the most famous photograph of the whole Depression. Ask: why has this one worried face come to stand for the suffering of millions? What does a single portrait do that a statistic like '25% unemployment' can't?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



Depression-era soup kitchen / breadline, New York City, early 1930s.

In plain words: The Great Depression caused huge human suffering. By 1933, about 25% of workers (15 million people) were jobless, with no unemployment insurance or safety net. Homeless families built shantytowns called 'Hoovervilles'; breadlines and hunger spread. The Depression hit unequally — Black Americans, already lowest on the job ladder, were often 'last hired, first fired.' Over 250,000 teenagers rode freight trains looking for work. Dorothea Lange's photo 'Migrant Mother' (1936) came to symbolize the era's suffering.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee's cities felt it hard. Memphis, Nashville, Knoxville, and Chattanooga all saw mass unemployment, breadlines, and makeshift shantytowns as trade and industry collapsed. The breadlines in the famous photographs had cousins on Tennessee streets — the Depression was not something that happened to other places. It happened in Tennessee too.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Mass unemployment and homelessness overwhelmed families, private charity, and local aid.
- **Head out of the sand:** The suffering millions themselves, and photographers and reporters who documented it.
- **Voice raised:** Breadlines, protests, and documentary images that forced the comfortable to see the crisis.
- **Government response:** Private and local relief collapsed under the need; a federal response would come only with the New Deal.
- **Still unfinished:** How a society ensures no one falls through to destitution remains a live debate.

✓ **Check:** Describe three ways the Depression harmed ordinary Americans, and explain why it fell harder on some groups than others. Why might a photograph like 'Migrant Mother' change minds when statistics don't?

Show what you know:

- Write the caption Dorothea Lange might attach to 'Migrant Mother' to make a stranger act.
 - Compare how the Depression affected Dot and Ruth in a short paragraph — same disaster, different weight.
 - Record a respectful 90-second 'this is what 25% unemployment felt like' explainer grounded in the sources.
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Spread 4 • US.42

Analyze Hoover's response to the Depression — 'rugged individualism,' the RFC, and the Bonus Army — and why it failed politically.

 You're the president. A quarter of the country is out of work, people are starving, and everyone is looking at you. You genuinely believe that if the government just hands out relief, it will make people weak and dependent — so you mostly say no. Now imagine being wrong about that in the worst possible moment. This is the tragedy of Herbert Hoover: not a cruel man, but a man whose deepest principle failed exactly when the country needed it to bend.

Archive brings the crew to the edge of a veterans' camp within sight of the U.S. Capitol. Frankie is already there, notebook out. 'The men in this camp fought for their country,' Archive says. 'Watch what happens when they ask their country for help — and watch a presidency end in the answer.'

PRIMARY VOICE

Herbert Hoover • rugged individualism

Hear Hoover's reasoning before you judge it. He wasn't heartless; he was a true believer in 'rugged individualism' — the idea that America's strength came from self-reliance, and that direct federal relief would corrode people's character and lead toward socialism. So he leaned on voluntary charity and on indirect help like the Reconstruction Finance Corporation, which lent two billion dollars to banks and businesses on the theory that aid at the top would 'trickle down' to workers. But the banks hoarded the money, the workers got little, and the charity ran dry. Hoover's principle was sincere. It was also, for this disaster, tragically inadequate.

GROUP

The Bonus Army • veterans at the gate

In the summer of 1932, more than 17,000 World War I veterans — hungry, jobless — marched to Washington to ask for early payment of a bonus they'd been promised, and camped peacefully with their families near the Capitol. Hoover ordered the Army to clear them out, and General Douglas MacArthur went further than ordered, using cavalry, tanks, bayonets, and tear gas against the veterans and their families. Two people were killed, hundreds injured, the camp burned. Newspapers ran photographs of U.S. soldiers attacking the very men who had fought for the country — and whatever was left of Hoover's support burned with the tents.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • the picture that ended a presidency

Frankie files the story, and he can feel it landing across the country. He's seen how images move people — from the Triangle fire to the Klan on Pennsylvania Avenue — and he knows this one is fatal. A nation looks at soldiers driving veterans from the capital with fire and gas, and it decides it has seen enough. That November, Franklin D. Roosevelt wins in a landslide — 42 of 48 states — the most decisive victory in generations. Frankie writes it plainly: the Bonus Army didn't just embarrass Hoover. It became the clearest possible argument that the country wanted its government to do something different.



 Bonus Army encampment at Anacostia, Washington, D.C., 1932.

[Bonus Army Camp, Anacostia, Washington, D.C.] (1932). Photograph, public domain (Great Depression era). Source: History Hack Primary Source & Image Bank (Unit 5); original repository and archival identifier to be confirmed by a human reviewer at Schedule F sign-off.

 This is the Bonus Army's camp at Anacostia, within sight of the Capitol, in 1932 — American flags flying over the shacks of jobless veterans. Ask: the men who built this camp had fought for their country. How does that change the meaning of the government's decision to burn it down?

In plain words: President Hoover believed in 'rugged individualism' — that people should rely on themselves and private charity, not government handouts, which he feared would weaken character and lead to socialism. His main tool, the Reconstruction Finance Corporation, lent money to banks and businesses hoping it would 'trickle down,' but little reached workers. In 1932, 17,000+ WWI veterans (the 'Bonus Army') camped in Washington seeking help; Hoover had the Army drive them out with tear gas and tanks. Photos of soldiers attacking veterans horrified the nation, and FDR won the 1932 election in a landslide.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee helped deliver the verdict on Hoover. Like most of the Democratic 'Solid South,' Tennessee voted overwhelmingly for Franklin D. Roosevelt in 1932, joining the national landslide that swept Hoover from office. The state's voters, hammered by the Depression and the Caldwell collapse, were ready for the dramatic change FDR promised.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A catastrophe too large for individuals and charity met a president philosophically opposed to federal relief.
- **Head out of the sand:** Jobless veterans, workers, and voters demanding that the government act.
- **Voice raised:** The Bonus Army march, mass protest, and ultimately the 1932 vote.
- **Government response:** Hoover held to limited, indirect measures; voters responded by electing FDR to do more.
- **Still unfinished:** The argument over whether government relief helps or harms self-reliance never fully ends.

✓ **Check:** Explain Hoover's philosophy of 'rugged individualism' and how it shaped his response to the Depression. Then explain how the Bonus Army episode helped end his presidency. Was his philosophy wrong, or just wrong for this crisis? Defend your view.

Show what you know:

- Write two headlines about the Bonus Army — one sympathetic to Hoover, one to the veterans — each fair to its side.
 - Make a 'what Hoover would and wouldn't do' chart, then mark where you agree and disagree.
 - Debate: was Hoover a failure, or a good man defeated by a crisis no philosophy could have handled? Use evidence.
-

Spread 5 • US.43

Analyze FDR's New Deal through the 'Three Rs' — Relief, Recovery, and Reform — and the lasting institutions it created.

 A minimum wage. A limit on your work week. Insurance so your grandparents don't starve when they're old. Insurance so your family's bank savings can't just vanish. You take all of that for granted — and none of it existed before the 1930s. In his first hundred days, a new president threw out the old rulebook and built, in a few frantic years, the safety net you're standing on right now. Whether that was rescue or overreach is the argument. That it changed your life is not.

Archive lands the crew on the Capitol steps as a new president takes the oath in March 1933. 'The banks are closed, the country's terrified, and this man has one job,' she says. 'Convince a broken nation that it can act — and then act faster than anyone thought a government could.'

PRIMARY VOICE

Franklin D. Roosevelt • 'fear itself'

FDR takes office in March 1933 at the very bottom, with the banking system collapsing, and the first thing he has to fix is the country's spirit. 'The only thing we have to fear,' he tells them in his inaugural address, 'is fear itself,' and he promises 'action, and action now.' It isn't just a nice line — it's a strategy. FDR grasps that a Depression is partly a panic, and that a paralyzed, frightened country can't recover. He closes the banks to stop the runs, reopens the sound ones under new rules, and gets on the radio in 'fireside chats' to explain it plainly. Confidence, he understood, is itself an economic tool.

INSTITUTION

The Three Rs • relief, recovery, reform

Then comes the flood of programs, organized around three goals. Relief — help right now: the Civilian Conservation Corps put millions of young men to work planting trees and building parks; the WPA built roads, bridges, schools, and hired artists and writers. Recovery — restart the economy: the AAA paid farmers to raise prices, the NRA set industry codes. Reform — fix the system so it can't break the same way again: the FDIC insured bank deposits and ended bank runs almost overnight, the SEC policed Wall Street, the Wagner Act protected unions, the Fair Labor Standards Act set a minimum wage and banned child labor, and — the crown jewel — Social Security created old-age and unemployment insurance that still supports Americans today.



ERA-FRIEND

Ruth • the New Deal's uneven reach

Ruth watches the New Deal with hope and a clear eye. It genuinely helps — relief jobs and Social Security are lifelines — and Black voters, long loyal to the party of Lincoln, begin shifting toward FDR's Democrats, forming a new coalition. But Ruth also sees the New Deal's blind spots: Social Security at first left out farm and domestic workers, jobs where most Black workers were concentrated, and many programs were run locally in ways that discriminated. Her verdict is honest and grown-up: the New Deal was a real rescue that still didn't reach everyone equally. Progress and unfinished business, in the same law.



 Civilian Conservation Corps (CCC) workers laying stone, c. 1933.

Civilian Conservation Corps Workers (c. 1933). Photograph, public domain (Great Depression era). Source: History Hack Primary Source & Image Bank (Unit 5); original repository and archival identifier to be confirmed by a human reviewer at Schedule F sign-off.

 These are Civilian Conservation Corps workers around 1933 — some of the millions of young men the New Deal put to work. Ask: instead of simply mailing people relief checks, the New Deal often paid them to build and plant things. Why might a government choose to give work rather than a handout — and who might that choice leave out?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



TVA Douglas Dam construction, Tennessee, 1942 — large crane labeled US TVA.

In plain words: FDR became president in 1933 and launched the New Deal to fight the Depression. He first calmed panic ('the only thing we have to fear is fear itself') and stabilized the banks. Then came many programs organized as the 'Three Rs': Relief (jobs now — CCC, WPA), Recovery (restart the economy — AAA, NRA), and Reform (fix the system — FDIC insured bank deposits, the SEC policed Wall Street, and Social Security created retirement and unemployment insurance). The New Deal helped millions and created lasting protections — but it didn't reach everyone equally; early Social Security left out many Black workers.

● **Tennessee:** The New Deal was everywhere in Tennessee. Civilian Conservation Corps camps put young Tennesseans to work in the state's forests and new parks, and WPA crews built roads, schools, and public buildings across the state. For a poor, rural state hammered by the Depression, the federal government suddenly became a visible, hands-on presence — building things Tennesseans used every day.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A catastrophe too big for individuals demanded a federal response no earlier government had attempted.
- **Head out of the sand:** A new president and Congress with a landslide mandate, and a public desperate for action.
- **Voice raised:** The 1932 election, fireside chats, and mass support for federal action.
- **Government response:** The New Deal built relief jobs and permanent reforms — FDIC, SEC, Social Security, the minimum wage — vastly expanding the federal role.
- **Still unfinished:** The New Deal's exclusions (e.g., many Black workers) and the size of the safety net are debated to this day.

✓ **Check:** Explain the 'Three Rs' of the New Deal with one program for each. Then explain one way the New Deal fell short of helping all Americans equally. Which New Deal program do you think mattered most, and why?

Show what you know:

- Sort the New Deal 'alphabet agencies' into Relief, Recovery, and Reform on a chart.
 - Write FDR's next fireside chat explaining one program to a scared, skeptical family.
 - Debate: which was the New Deal's most important legacy — Social Security, the FDIC, or the minimum wage? Use evidence.
-

Spread 6 • US.43

Analyze the Tennessee Valley Authority as the New Deal's most dramatic regional transformation — flood control, electrification, and its impact on rural Tennessee.

💡 Flip a switch. Light. You've done it ten thousand times without a thought. Now imagine you're seventeen and you have never once done it — every night of your life lit by a smoky kerosene lamp, every drop of water hauled by hand, every summer's food spoiling for lack of ice. Then one day the government strings a wire to your farmhouse, and with one flip, your family steps from the 1800s into the modern world. In the Tennessee Valley, that actually happened — and it started right here.

Archive brings the crew home to East Tennessee and finds Vernon on a dark farm, a kerosene lamp in the window. 'Of all the New Deal did,' she says, 'nothing changed daily life more than what's about to happen in this valley. Watch the twentieth century arrive — on a wire.'



ERA-FRIEND

Vernon • the day the lights came on

You've followed Vernon since the Twenties — the devout East Tennessee farm boy who feared the modern world was leaving his community behind. Now he's a young man on a farm with no electricity, like nine out of ten rural households in the region. Then the Tennessee Valley Authority arrives. The TVA builds dams across the valley and strings power lines out to farms like Vernon's, and one evening the bulb overhead simply glows. No more kerosene, no more hauling water by hand, no more food spoiling. For Vernon, who once felt modernity was a threat, the New Deal is the thing that finally includes him. The government didn't leave his valley behind. It turned the lights on.

INSTITUTION

The TVA • a government builds a region

The TVA was one of the boldest ideas in American history: a government-owned corporation charged with remaking an entire region. It built a chain of dams — Norris, Douglas, and many more — that controlled the floods that had regularly ravaged the valley, improved river navigation, and generated cheap public electricity. It replanted eroded land and taught better farming. Where private power companies had seen no profit in wiring poor rural farms, the TVA did it anyway, because its goal wasn't profit — it was lifting up a whole region. For millions across Tennessee, Alabama, and Kentucky, the TVA was the New Deal you could see from your porch.



📷 TVA Douglas Dam construction, Tennessee, 1942 — large crane labeled US TVA.

'Douglas Dam, Tennessee. Tennessee Valley Authority (TVA) construction.' Photograph, 1942. FSA/OWI Collection, U.S. government (public domain).

💡 This is Douglas Dam under construction in Tennessee in 1942 — look for the 'US TVA' label on the crane. Ask: this dam was built by the federal government, not a private company. What can a government build that a business might not — and what worries might people have about the government owning the power?

In plain words: The Tennessee Valley Authority (TVA), created in 1933, was one of the New Deal's boldest programs. A government-owned corporation, it built a system of dams (like Norris and Douglas) across the Tennessee Valley to control flooding, improve river travel, and generate cheap electricity. Before the TVA, only about one in ten rural households in the region had electric power. The TVA brought electricity to hundreds of thousands of rural families — transforming daily life — while also fighting soil erosion. It changed the region more visibly than almost any other New Deal program.

● **Tennessee:** This entire spread is Tennessee — the TVA is named for the Tennessee Valley, and it is headquartered in the state. It built Norris Dam, Douglas Dam, and a network of others across East and Middle Tennessee, ending the floods that had plagued the valley and bringing electricity to hundreds of thousands of rural Tennesseans who had never had power. No New Deal transformation anywhere in the country was more dramatic — and it happened in Tennessee's own backyard.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** An impoverished, flood-prone region had no electricity because private companies saw no profit in it.
- **Head out of the sand:** New Deal planners and rural residents who wanted power, flood control, and development.
- **Voice raised:** Federal legislation creating a public authority to serve the region directly.
- **Government response:** The TVA built dams, controlled floods, and electrified the rural Tennessee Valley — a government doing what the market wouldn't.
- **Still unfinished:** Whether the government should own and run things like power utilities remains debated — even as the TVA still operates.

✓ **Check:** Explain what the TVA did and why it mattered so much to the rural South. Then explain one benefit and one cost or controversy of a government building and owning something like the TVA.

Show what you know:

- Write Vernon's diary entry the night the electric light first comes on in his house.
 - Draw a 'before and after TVA' picture of a Tennessee Valley farm, labeling what changed.
 - Debate: was the TVA a model of good government or government overreach? Use its benefits and costs.
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Analyze the opposition to the New Deal, the Supreme Court's rejection of key programs, and FDR's failed court-packing plan.

 What happens when a president does so much, so fast, that people start asking whether he's rescuing democracy or endangering it? The New Deal saved millions — and it terrified critics who saw a government growing too big, a leader gathering too much power. When the Supreme Court started striking down his programs, FDR tried to stack the Court in his favor — and even his own allies said he'd gone too far. The New Deal's biggest fight wasn't with the Depression. It was over the Constitution itself.

Archive sets the crew outside the Supreme Court as reporters swarm the steps. Frankie's in the crowd. 'Every good idea in this unit has an argument on the other side,' Archive says. 'Now watch the country wrestle with the hardest question of all: how much power should one government — and one president — have?'

INSTITUTION

The opposition • 'is this still America?'

The New Deal had fierce and sincere critics, and their fears deserve a fair hearing. Conservatives and business leaders formed the American Liberty League and accused FDR of dragging the country toward socialism, of destroying free enterprise; some called him 'a traitor to his class.' Then the Supreme Court weighed in hard: it struck down the NRA in 1935 (the 'sick chicken' Schechter case) and the AAA in 1936, ruling that FDR's government had grabbed powers the Constitution didn't grant it. To the opposition, this wasn't obstruction — it was the constitutional guardrails doing exactly their job against a president reaching too far.

PRIMARY VOICE

FDR • fighting back and overreaching

FDR fought back hard — sometimes too hard. He blasted the 'economic royalists' who, he charged, cared more for their power than for suffering people. But when the Court kept blocking him, he made a serious mistake: in 1937 he proposed adding up to six new justices to the Supreme Court — 'court-packing' — to manufacture a majority that would uphold the New Deal. It backfired badly. Even FDR's own allies recoiled, seeing it as a power grab that threatened the balance between the branches, and Congress rejected it. It was FDR's first big political defeat, a reminder that even a wildly popular president can overreach.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • the system holds

Frankie has spent five units watching Americans fight over power, and he sees the deeper story here. Soon after the court fight, the Court itself began upholding New Deal laws — a shift nicknamed 'the switch in time that saved nine' — and the court-packing plan quietly died as unnecessary. Frankie writes down what it all means: the New Deal permanently expanded the federal government, AND the Constitution's checks held, blocking a president who reached too far. Both things are the point. A country can transform itself and still keep the guardrails that stop any one person from having too much. That balance, Frankie notes, is the whole experiment.



 WPA 'Work Pays America! Prosperity' poster, Works Progress Administration, 1936.

'Work Pays America! Prosperity.' Poster, c. 1936. Works Progress Administration, Federal Art Project, U.S. government (public domain).

 This is a WPA poster from 1936 — government-made art promoting government jobs. Ask: critics said the New Deal used taxpayer money to build support for itself. Is a poster like this helpful public information, or government propaganda — and how can you tell the difference?

In plain words: The New Deal had powerful critics. Business leaders (the American Liberty League) called it socialism and FDR 'a traitor to his class.' The Supreme Court struck down two big programs — the NRA (1935) and AAA (1936) — as unconstitutional. Frustrated, FDR proposed in 1937 to add up to six justices ('court-packing') to get rulings he wanted, but even his allies rejected it as a power grab. Soon after, the Court started upholding New Deal laws anyway. The result: the New Deal greatly expanded federal power, but the Constitution's checks still limited the president.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee's own TVA sat right at the center of this fight. Because the government-owned TVA sold electricity in competition with private power companies, critics saw it as exactly the kind of socialism they feared, and private interests challenged it in court. In *Ashwander v. TVA* (1936), the Supreme Court upheld the TVA's constitutionality — a key victory that let the New Deal's boldest experiment, born in Tennessee, survive.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A rapid, sweeping expansion of federal power collided with constitutional limits and fears of one-man rule.
- **Head out of the sand:** Business critics, the Supreme Court, and members of Congress across parties.
- **Voice raised:** Court challenges, the American Liberty League, congressional debate, and the press.
- **Government response:** The Court struck down some programs and blocked court-packing, then upheld later New Deal laws — settling an expanded but checked federal role.
- **Still unfinished:** The size of government and the limits of presidential power are argued in every generation since.

✓ **Check:** Explain why the New Deal faced opposition, how the Supreme Court responded, and why FDR's court-packing plan failed. What does this fight show about the balance of power in American government?

Show what you know:

- Make a T-chart: the New Deal as 'necessary rescue' vs. 'dangerous overreach,' with evidence on both sides.
 - Write a senator's speech either supporting or opposing FDR's court-packing plan.
 - Debate: was FDR's court-packing plan a reasonable response to an obstructive Court, or a threat to democracy? Use evidence.
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Toward a more perfect union

This unit is where America rewrites the deal between a person and their government. For 150 years the answer to 'who catches you when you fall' was mostly 'you do, or your family and church do.' The Depression was so vast that answer broke — private charity ran dry while millions starved. Watch the country decide, through fierce argument, that some catastrophes are too big for individuals alone, and build the safety net — Social Security, deposit insurance, the minimum wage, the TVA — that still holds you up today. It was not a clean victory, and plenty of Americans thought it went too far. But it is one of the biggest turns in the whole story: the moment the federal government took responsibility for the economic security of ordinary people.

Closing question: The New Deal permanently expanded what the federal government does for ordinary people — and Americans have argued about whether that was rescue or overreach ever since. Using at least two programs from this unit, argue whether the New Deal moved the country closer to its founding promise or further from it. Then name one thing it left unfinished. Cite the unit — there's no answer key.

This unit on the Arc of the Union

You decide: did each of these move the country **toward** its founding promise of liberty and equality for all — or away from it? There's no answer key — mark your own read and defend it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1929	The stock market crash	Black Tuesday triggers bank failures, layoffs, and a decade of depression.	
1932	The Bonus Army is driven from Washington	Troops burn the veterans' camp; the images help end Hoover's presidency.	
1933	The New Deal begins	FDR launches Relief, Recovery, and Reform, remaking the federal role — though its early benefits did not reach all Americans equally.	

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1933	The TVA lights up the Tennessee Valley	A government agency brings power and flood control to the rural South, though some families were displaced by the rising reservoirs.	
1935	Social Security is enacted	Old-age and unemployment insurance become a permanent part of American life — though farm and domestic workers were left out at first.	
1937	The court-packing plan fails	Even FDR's allies reject packing the Court; the checks-and-balances system holds.	